Achieving Goals: The Role of Support & Structure for Latina/o Student Goals

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Significance

- 8.4% of MN public school students identify as Latina/o.
- 24%of US public school students identify as Latina/o.
- 53% of Latina/o MN high school students graduate.
- Latina/os represent the fastest growing population of the United States.
- After-school activities play a critical role in positive youth development and success for all youth.

Latina/o Critical Theory

- LatCrit is important because Latina/o students have been constantly undermined and unacknowledged as intellectual learners by policy makers and researchers.
- Many Latina/o students are wrongly placed in remedial level courses or special education classrooms. Research on Latina/o youth is overwhelmingly based on deficit liabilities rather than positive assets.

Mixed-Methods

- 2013 ***Minnesota Student Survey***; descriptive analysis of Latina/o student responses for TSS and OST activities
  - **2763** 9th graders
  - **2090** 11th graders
- Interviewed 4 Latina/o high school students
- Interviewed 3 Teachers and 1 Counselor

Student Perspectives

" [My] math teacher goes out of his way to make sure [students] understand what he's teaching…"

" I feel like [my] teachers understand [me], if a student is feeling moody in any type of way teachers intervene to try and improve your mood, make you focus again."

"…If [teachers] tried harder it would've been okay but they just didn't care. That made me not want to learn…"

"I felt like the school wasn't giving me enough support and the teachers...didn't care if I learned or not."

"…Every semester starts with students writing or telling a story about themselves… [we are] always communicating. Teachers notice right away when something is going on with the student and they'll pull you out of class and talk to you…"

"…I know English but the teachers here know Spanish so it's easier to learn…"

"I feel comfortable with every teacher… I can talk to them and explain if I'm missing something… I feel like I actually learn more things and I'm coming to school more… I barely even skip anymore. I want to be in school."

Research Questions

Researchers have shown how important it is for Latina/o students to be supported and engaged and to have high goals (predicts greater success).

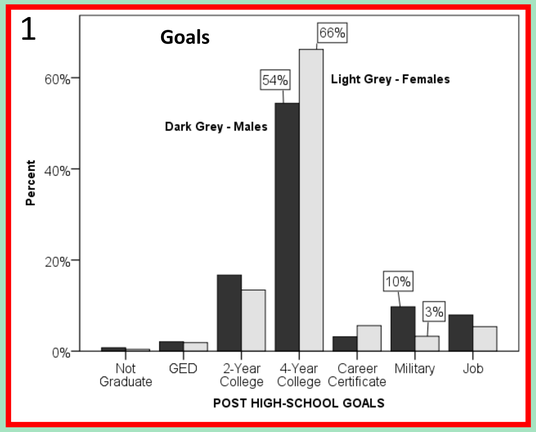
For Latina/o students, are there associations between
1. Grades and Teacher/School Support?
2. Goals and TSS?
3. Goals and participation in supervised, structured, or academic after-school activities?

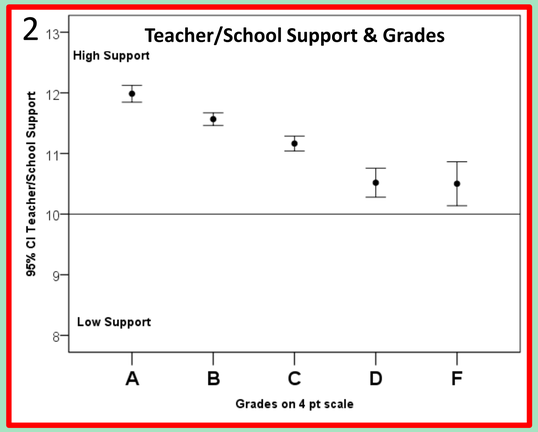
Main Findings

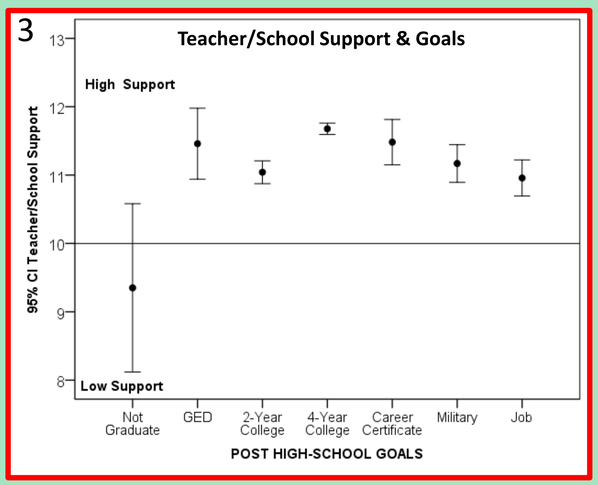
- There are small gender differences in goals set by Latina versus Latino high school students.
- Students with higher GPAs report higher TSS.
- Students with 4-year college goals report higher TSS.
- Students with 4-year college and career-certificate goals are participating in more structured OST activities and less unstructured activities than students with other goals.
- Although students with 4-year college and career-certificate goals participate in more structured activities, it is unrelated to whether activities are academic or nonacademic.

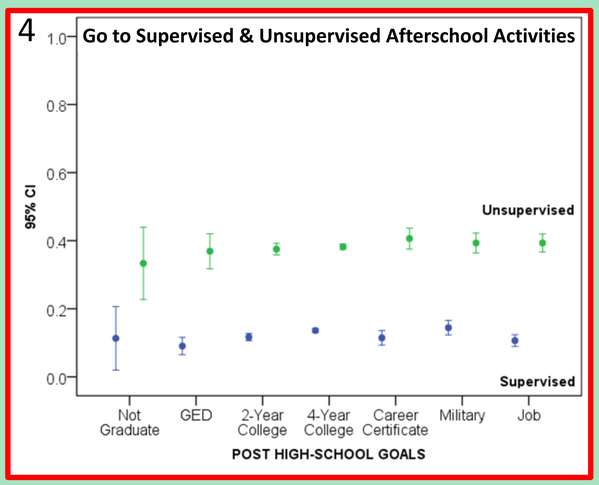
Further Research:

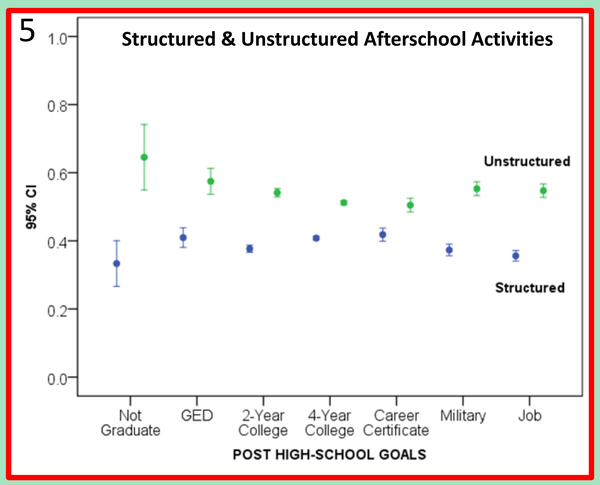
- Are Latina/o students with high levels of support who are engaged in structured activities more likely to graduate from high school and achieve their goals?

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